

Bucking the politicians' trend of concealing income and declaring assets that have quadrupled in three years, Mayawati remains unfazed as opponents and media hound her

■ By Subhash Mishra

Here is something that could make fund managers and investment advisors turn green with envy, if not seethe in impotent rage. A mere three years ago, while contesting for Lok Sabha from the Akbarpur constituency in the state, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati had, in a mandatory affidavit, declared that she owned property and other assets worth Rs 11.78 crore. Last week, as she prepared to contest the election to the Uttar Pradesh legislative council, Mayawati turned up before the poll returning officer in Lucknow and promptly swore a fresh affidavit that said she was now worth Rs 52 crore.

Politicians, like everyone else, are entitled to wealth creation and the Uttar Pradesh chief minister is no exception. What perhaps makes her different is that unlike most other politicians, she has been honest enough to declare that she has more than quadrupled her wealth in the last three years, strangely at a time when she was not even in power, traditionally the time when politicians milk the exchequer to fill their own coffers.

It is perhaps this honesty that made newspapers give banner headlines about "Mayawati's disproportionate assets" and tv channels ran chat shows about the "millionaire school teacher". Just the kind of stuff that makes her livid.

Which is just what happened. Mayawati called a news conference in Lucknow and almost tauntingly told reporters that her wealth had quadrupled due to the love and affection of her party cadre. "My party workers from all over the country gifted me the money and told me, 'Sister, you do whatever you want with this money, even buy bungalows if you want to'".

Mayawati seemed to have heeded their advice since the affidavit shows that this daughter of a post office employee now owns, among other

POOR LITTLE RICH GIRL

SIPRA DAS

